

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Christmas Eve

24 December 2025 | 8pm



Bethlehem Star 2 © 2018 Virginia Wieringa, virginiawieringa.com

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions...We extend a warm welcome to all this evening and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~ Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Christmas Eve Prelude Concert

On Christmas Night - SUSSEX CAROL (William Rose) and Improvisation

DIVINUM MYSTERIUM (Improvisation)

Chaconne in G-moll, BWV 1178 (Johann Sebastian Bach)

Toccata, Adagio and Fugue in C Major, BWV 564 (Johann Sebastian Bach)

Proclamation of the Birth of Christ (Christoph Bull)

Scott Graff, *Soloist*, Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Chiming of the Hour

Christmas Eve Antiphon

*"Ukrainian Bell Carol" MYKOLA LEONTOVICH, arr. PETER WILHOUSKY
Cathedral Choir, Dr. Ianthe Marini, Assistant Conductor*

Welcome to This Night

Rev. Michael Lehman & Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

With eyes wide open
and our ears on edge,
Tonight, we look for shepherds
and listen for the songs of angels.

In the light of the winter's moon,
with the North Star lighting the way,
we gather outside the door of mystery,
wondering if we dare to enter.

With friends we love,
with strangers we have just met,
we gather becoming a holy family
in this sacred time and place.

May this time together
speak to our hearts and minds
as we embrace the Light of the World.

On this night, may it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

**Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Christmas Eve Processional*

***Christmas Eve Processional**

"O Come All Ye Faithful"

**O Come, All Ye Faithful, joyful and triumphant,
O come ye, O come ye, to Bethlehem.
Come and behold the ruler of all angels:
O Come in adoration, O come in adoration,
O Come in adoration, Christ the Lord!*

God of true God... Light of true light...
born of the Virgin's womb in human form;
Truly our God, begotten, not created:
O Come in adoration, O come in adoration,
O Come in adoration, Christ the Lord!

Sing, choirs of angels, sing in exultation,
sing, all you messengers of heavenly love:
'Glory to God, all glory in the highest':
O Come in adoration, O come in adoration,
O Come in adoration, Christ the Lord!

Yes, Lord, we greet thee, born for our salvation,
Jesus, to you shall all glory be given;
Word of our God... now in flesh appearing;
O Come in adoration, O come in adoration,
O Come in adoration, Christ the Lord!

***Lighting of the Christ Candle**

Hope, peace, joy, and love.
Four candles, four promises continually offered to us by God,
and all of them manifest in this one we light tonight: the Christ candle.

In Christ we find the hope of transformation,
the peace that follows justice, the joy of self-fulfillment in community,
and the love that encompasses us in all our diversity,
empowering us to make our own unique contribution to this world.

In Christ we find light and life, and the courage to be like Christ,
answering the call and following in the footsteps of the Christ.

Come, let us adore the Christ Child.

***Congregational Carol**

Sing We Now of Christmas

NOEL NOUVELET

Sing we now of Christmas, Noël sing we here!
Hear our grateful praises to the child so dear.
Sing we Noël, Jesus is born, Noël, Noël!
Sing we Noël, Jesu is born, Noël!
Sing we now of Christmas, let us sing Noël!

Angels called the Shepherds "Leave your flocks at rest,
Journey forth to Bethlehem find the child so blest."
Sing we Noël, Jesus is born, Noël, Noël!
Sing we Noël, Jesus is born, Noël!
Sing we now of Christmas, let us sing Noël!

In Bethlehem they found them; Joseph and Mary mild,
Seated by the manger, watching the holy child.
Sing we Noël, Jesus is born, Noël, Noël!
Sing we Noël, Jesus is born, Noël!
Sing we now of Christmas, let us sing Noël!

The Story of this Night

Rev. Lehman

The Light ~ from Isaiah 9

Doug Hart

This is the Light from the Prophet Isaiah, chapter 9.

The people walking in the deepest night
are seeing a brilliant light –
upon those who dwell
in a land of deep shadows
light is shining!

For a child is born to us,
an heir is given us,
upon whose shoulders
dominion will rest.

This one shall be called
wonderful counselor,
the strength of God,
Eternal Protector,
Champion of Peace.

This dominion, and this peace,
will grow without end,
with David's throne and realm
sustained with justice and fairness,
now and forever.

The zeal of YHWH Omnipotent
will accomplish it!

Musical Response

"For Unto Us A Child Is Born" from *Messiah*
Cathedral Choir, Brandon Harris, *Conductor*

G.F. HANDEL

The Promise ~ from Luke 1

Katherine Lambert

Musical Response

"Wexford Carol" TRADITIONAL IRISH CAROL, arr. DAVID HARRIS
Cathedral Choir, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Flute*, Dr. Fahad Siadat, *Assistant Director*

The Journey to Bethlehem ~ from Luke 2

Jason Lambert

Musical Response

"O Holy Night" ADOLPHE ADAM, arr. DAVID HARRIS
Cathedral Choir, Dr. David Harris, *Director*, Christin Byrdsong, *Soloist*

The Shepherds & Angels ~ Luke 2

Russell Alexander-Orozco

**Please stand, in body or in spirit.*

***The Music of the People**

Angels We Have Heard on High, sweetly singing o'er the plains,
And the mountains in reply echo back their joyous strains.
Gloria, in excelsis Deo,
Gloria, in excelsis Deo.

Shepherds, why this jubilee? Why your joyous strains prolong?
Say what may the tidings be, which inspire your heav'nly song.
Gloria, in excelsis Deo,
Gloria, in excelsis Deo.

What Child is This, who, laid to rest, On Mary's lap is sleeping?
Whom angels greet with anthems sweet, while shepherds watch are keeping?
Praise, praise to Jesus bring whom shepherds guard and angels sing.
Haste, haste your praise to bring, the Babe, the child of Mary.

Why lies the child, in manger bare where ox and ass are feeding?
The Holy Child, though meek and mild, has come with God's salvation.
Raise, raise the song on high, the mother sings her lullaby;
Joy, joy, for Christ is born, the Babe, the child of Mary.

Hark! the Herald Angels Sing, "Glory, Hallelujahs ring!;
Peace on earth and mercy mild, God and people reconciled!"
Joyful, all ye nations, rise, join the triumph of the skies;
With the angelic hosts proclaim, "Jesus is born in Bethlehem!"
Hark! The herald angels sing, "Glory, Hallelujahs ring!"

Hail the heav'n-born Prince of Peace, hail the sun of righteousness!
Light and life to all They bring, ris'n with healing in Their wings.
Mild They lay Their glory by, born that we no more may die,
Born to raise the children of earth, born to give us second birth.
Hark! The herald angels sing, "Glory, Hallelujahs ring!"

The Good News ~ Luke 2

Rev. Fregin

This is the Gospel of Grace.
Thanks be to God!

Musical Response

"Gesu Bambino"

PIETRO YON

Katelyn Dietz and Molly Pease, *Soloists*, Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organ*

A Prayer for Christmas Eve

Rev. Lehman

Holy One,
in this moment in time,
it is the silence
that whispers joy
into our lives.

Silence

Tonight, in this sacred space,
let the comfort of familiar carols,
filled with notes of hope,
take away the despair
which envelops us,
and our world.

Tonight, in familiar words heard anew,
speak to us of the grace
that is born into our lives
and of the peace which is birthed,
in the midst of our shadowed fears.

Tonight, O God, as we lean in close to those
who have always been a part of us,
and those from whom we have been apart,
remind us of your heart
which always finds room for us,
and welcomes us just as we are.

Tonight, in the depths of the love
which is ours forever,
draw us closer to your heart,
so we can be surprised by wonder,
swaddled in serenity,
and embraced by tenderness.

Then, O God, touch us again with Christmas,
as we breathe in the beauty of this sacred and holy space.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

Christmas Reflection

Rev. Fregin

Invitation to Offering

Rev. Lehman

May the God of Silent Nights be with us!
May the God of Herald Angels be with us!
May the God of Faithful Shepherds be with us!
May the God of open hearts be with us,
as we join together in sharing with joy,
our hope, peace, and love.

*In the days to come,
may our voices blend with those of the angels and shepherds,
as we work together for justice and peace in our lives,
in our city, and in our world.*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Offertory

"Consolamini"

BRITTANY ELIZABETH BOYKIN

Laude, Dr. David Harris, *Director*

*"Hear these words of comfort for all people: the light shall not wait. Why do you choose to waste away in sadness?
Fear not, for I offer grace. I am the Divine, and my love renews all things."*

**Please stand, in body or in spirit.*

*Christmas Eve Offertory Response

"The First Noël"

THE FIRST NOEL

The first Noël the angel did say
was to certain poor shepherds in fields as they lay,
in fields where they lay keeping their sheep,
on a cold winter's night that was so deep.

Refrain

Noël, Noël, Noël, Noël,
Jesus is born, let us sing Noël.

Please be seated.

The Beginning ~ from John 1

The Lighting of the Candles

Music of the Night

Silent Night

STILLE NACHT

Silent night, holy night,
All is calm, all is bright
Round yon virgin mother and child.
Holy infant, so tender and mild,
Sleep in heavenly peace,
Sleep in heavenly peace.

Silent night, holy night,
Shepherds quake at the sight;
Glories stream from heaven afar,
Heavenly hosts sing Alleluia!
Christ the Savior is born,
Christ the Savior is born!

Silent night, holy night,
Son of God, love's pure light;
Radiant beams from thy holy face
With the dawn of redeeming grace,
Jesus, Lord, at thy birth,
Jesus, Lord, at thy birth.

Words for the Journey

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Christmas comes every time we see God in other people.
The human and the holy will meet in Bethlehem
or in MacArthur Park,
for Christmas comes like a golden storm on its way

to Jerusalem –
determinedly, inevitably...

Even now it comes
in the face of a world that is not perfect –
but there is nothing too terrible to stop it,
no kingdom strong enough,
no hurt deep enough,
no words shocking enough,
no disaster shattering enough.

For someone on earth will always see the star,
someone will hear the angel voices,
someone will run to Bethlehem,
someone will know peace and goodwill:
for the Christ will be born again!

***Christmas Eve Recessional** *Joy to the World*

Joy to the world! The Christ is here!
The gift of peace to bring!
Let ev'ry heart a welcome place prepare.
And heav'n and nature sing,
And heav'n and nature sing,
And heav'n, and heav'n and nature sing!

Joy to the earth! The Savior lives!
With song your voice employ;
While fields and floods, rock, plains and hills
Repeat the sounding joy,
Repeat the sounding joy,
Repeat, repeat the sounding joy!

Christ fills the world with truth and grace,
And asks each life to prove
The glories of God's righteousness
And wonders of God's love,
And wonders of God's love,
And wonders, and wonders of God's love! *GPHaddon*

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-In-Residence

Toccata in C Major - Reprise, BWV 564/1 (Johann Sebastian Bach)